

SENG 310 PROJECT PROPOSAL

PROBLEM: In today's fast paced world, spending quality time with family and friends acts as an activity that provides numerous benefits to one's mental health (Acoba, 2024) . However, balancing this activity with everybody's busy schedules is becoming increasingly tedious (Pederson & Lewis, 2012).

MOTIVATION: Making the act of finding periods of time where all one's friends are free to spend time with each other easier will help increase an individual's overall social activity and thereby positively impact their mental health. Through our online scheduling web app that helps a friend group find times where they are all free to "hang out" easily, we aim to combat this problem.

SOLUTION: We aim to create an application that gives a user access to two main sections.

The first is the personal section where a user can input their schedule into a calendar-like interface, marking periods of time every week where they are free and others where they are busy. We also aim to provide a manner in which a user can connect their Google Calendar (using the Google Calendar RESTful API) and automatically load a pre existing schedule onto the app in order to reduce the need of creating multiple schedules every week if they already use pre-existing software to do so.

Sketch of the personal calendar section

Import from a calendar etc (.ics)

The sketch illustrates the personal calendar section of the application. It includes an 'IMPORT' button at the top left, with a handwritten note 'Import from a calendar etc (.ics)' pointing to it. Below the button is a 'DATE: / /' input field. To the right of the date field is a calendar grid with red highlights indicating specific days. Below the calendar grid is a form for adding or editing events, with fields for 'EVENT NAME', 'PRIORITY', and a date field labeled 'DD/MM/YY'. The form is divided into sections by dashed lines. To the right of the form is a list of events, each represented by a red highlight, indicating a schedule or availability.

The second section is one we propose calling the 'Groups' section where a user will be able to join multiple friend groups via a nine digit code. This page will consist of a number of elements representing groups the user is a part of laid down from top to bottom. Besides these group elements, on one side, there will be two sub sections labelled 'Create Group' and 'Join Group'.

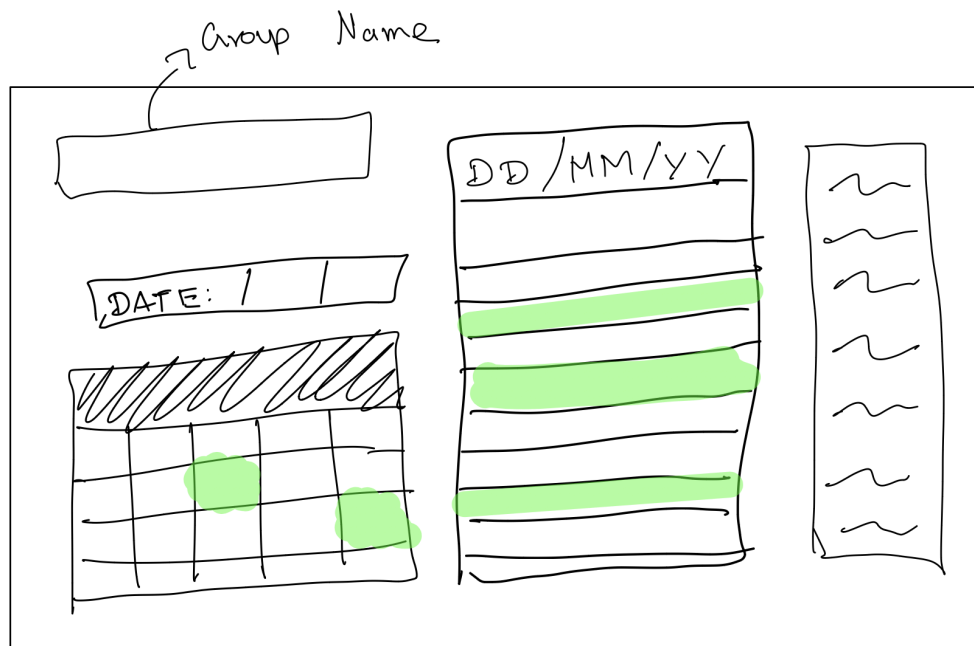
Sketch of the 'Groups' section

The sketch is divided into two main panels. The left panel is titled 'GROUPS' and contains a 'Search:' label followed by a three-part input field. Below this is a large rectangular area, and further down is a 'JOIN' button. At the bottom of the left panel is a 'Create Group' button next to a small icon of a group. The right panel is titled 'CURRENT GROUPS' and contains four horizontal rectangular elements, each with a 'leave' button at its right end.

When a user clicks on 'Create Group', they will be given an automatically generated nine digit code that their friends can use to join their group. When a user clicks on 'Join Group', they will be greeted with a textbox that allows them to enter the respective nine digit code of their group and join it. Upon joining, a new element representing that group will be added.

When a user clicks on an element representing a group, they are shown a calendar-like interface representing the times where different members of the group are available or busy. We aim to use different colours to represent times when particular users are busy or free and another colour where everyone is free. The interface will also have a text based component that displays the times where everybody is free.

Sketch of group calendar



We also aim to add additional features that provide users the ability to text other users in a group, get notifications for planned events and block periods of time for an event. We're also exploring avenues that allow users to spend more time with each other via gamification. Here, users will be able to win in-app rewards every time they block an amount of time to spend with each other.

References

Acoba E. F. (2024) Social support and mental health: The mediating role of perceived stress. *Frontiers in Psychology*, 15, 1330720.

<https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2024.1330720>

Pederson V. B. & Lewis S. (2012) Flexible friends? Flexible working time arrangements, blurred work-life boundaries and friendship. *Work, Employment and Society*, 26(3), 464-480.. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0950017012438571>

